



CHAPTER 1

EARTH AND SPACE

To us, our planet Earth seems enormous, but if we were able to gaze at it across the vastness of space, it would look like a tiny speck. It is one of the eight planets that are constantly hurtling around a star—our sun—along individual elliptical paths called orbits.

Together, the sun and its planets are known as the solar system. This, in turn, is part of a cluster of millions of stars and planets, called a galaxy. Our galaxy, which is shaped like a spiral, is called the Milky Way. It is so huge that a jet would take more than 100 billion years to fly across it. Scientists think that there are at least 200 billion different galaxies in our universe.

Stars are made from layers of burning gas around a dense core. Some planets are also mostly gas, but other planets and moons are rocky, like Earth.

Earth
Space

